
SESSION 4A

KNOW YOUR ENEMY

KNOW YOUR ENEMY

Again and again the bible teaches that we are in the midst of a great struggle, a spiritual war and that Christians are called to join God in this cosmic contest, fighting for souls and for eternal stakes.



Enemy-occupied territory—that is what this world is. Christianity is the story of how the rightful king has landed, you might say landed in disguise, and is calling us all to take part in a great campaign of sabotage. ¹

– C.S. Lewis, *Mere Christianity*

Knowing the enemy is as important for a Christian as for a military commander—both are engaged in battle. It would be foolish for a Christian to not take the reality of spiritual battle seriously. As you study the materials in this section, pay particular attention to Satan’s characteristics and how he operates, “in order that Satan might not outwit us. For we are not unaware of his schemes.” [2 Corinthians 2:11]



EPHESIANS 6:12 (ESV)

¹²For we do not wrestle against flesh and blood, but against the rulers, against the authorities, against the cosmic powers over this present darkness, against the spiritual forces of evil in the heavenly places.

2 CORINTHIANS 10:3-5 (ESV)

³For though we walk in the flesh, we are not waging war according to the flesh. ⁴For the weapons of our warfare are not of the flesh but have divine power to destroy strongholds. ⁵We destroy arguments and every lofty opinion raised against the knowledge of God, and take every thought captive to obey Christ,

Review the verses above and answer the question below.

How is the Christian struggle characterized and against whom do we struggle?

¹ Lewis, C.S. *Mere Christianity*. New York: Harper Collins, 2001. pp. 45-56.

WHAT CAN WE LEARN ABOUT SATAN?

The Christian struggle is characterized as open warfare against the spiritual forces of evil over the world, and each and every believer is a part of this ongoing battle. Clearly, we are in the war of wars. And we face a stealthy, ingenious, and ruthless enemy: Satan. Satan makes it his continual business to cast doubt on God's word and to discredit God's Son.

What can we learn about Satan in the following verses?

LUKE 8:12 (ESV)

¹²The ones along the path are those who have heard; then the devil comes and takes away the word from their hearts, so that they may not believe and be saved.

JOHN 8:44 (ESV)

⁴⁴You are of your father the devil, and your will is to do your father's desires. He was a murderer from the beginning, and does not stand in the truth, because there is no truth in him. When he lies, he speaks out of his own character, for he is a liar and the father of lies.

2 CORINTHIANS 4:3-4 (ESV)

³And even if our gospel is veiled, it is veiled to those who are perishing. ⁴In their case the god of this world has blinded the minds of the unbelievers, to keep them from seeing the light of the gospel of the glory of Christ, who is the image of God.

2 CORINTHIANS 11:14 (ESV)

¹⁴And no wonder, for even Satan disguises himself as an angel of light.

1 PETER 5:8 (ESV)

⁸Be sober-minded; be watchful. Your adversary the devil prowls around like a roaring lion, seeking someone to devour.

REVELATION 12:9 (ESV)

⁹And the great dragon was thrown down, that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world—he was thrown down to the earth, and his angels were thrown down with him.

WHEN JESUS CONFRONTED SATAN



LUKE 4:1-13 (ESV)

¹ And Jesus, full of the Holy Spirit, returned from the Jordan and was led by the Spirit in the wilderness ²for forty days, being tempted by the devil. And he ate nothing during those days. And when they were ended, he was hungry. ³The devil said to him, “If you are the Son of God, command this stone to become bread.” ⁴And Jesus answered him, “It is written, ‘Man shall not live by bread alone.’” ⁵And the devil took him up and showed him all the kingdoms of the world in a moment of time, ⁶and said to him, “To you I will give all this authority and their glory, for it has been delivered to me, and I give it to whom I will. ⁷If you, then, will worship me, it will all be yours.” ⁸And Jesus answered him, “It is written,

“‘You shall worship the Lord your God,
and him only shall you serve.’”

⁹And he took him to Jerusalem and set him on the pinnacle of the temple and said to him, “If you are the Son of God, throw yourself down from here,¹⁰ for it is written,

“‘He will command his angels concerning you,
to guard you,’

¹¹and

“‘On their hands they will bear you up,
lest you strike your foot against a stone.’”

¹²And Jesus answered him, “It is said, ‘You shall not put the Lord your God to the test.’” ¹³And when the devil had ended every temptation, he departed from him until an opportune time.

Review the account of Christ’s confrontation with Satan in Luke 4:1-13 from the video and answer the questions below.

What was Jesus’ physical condition when the devil appeared?

What desires did Satan appeal to in the three temptations?

What does v. 13 indicate about Satan’s strategy?

What would be an opportune time (or circumstance) for the devil to tempt you?

CLAIMING OUR ASSURED VICTORY

From Luke 4 we see Satan's strategy and opportunistic behavior in the way that he goes about trying to tempt Jesus. He comes at a time when Jesus is alone, hungry, tired, and physically weak to tempt him, appealing to the human desire for food, appealing to man's desire for wealth and power, as well as to a common temptation to put God to the test to see whether or not he is faithful to us in our time of need. Jesus goes on to rebut each of Satan's temptations and advances by calling on the word of God and ultimately, Satan leaves Jesus' presence to continue to prowl and wait for an opportune time. This passage shows us that if Satan has the audacity to tempt Jesus the son of God, then he will not hesitate to unleash onslaught after onslaught upon us, Jesus' disciples.

As active as Satan is in resisting the will of God on earth, he is a defeated enemy. When Jesus died on the cross and then rose from the grave, he won the victory over Satan, sin and death. And Jesus' victory is ours as well.

Read the following passages. Note the words having to do with "victory."



COLOSSIANS 2:15 (ESV)

¹⁵ He disarmed the rulers and authorities and put them to open shame, by triumphing over them in him.

1 JOHN 5:4-5 (ESV)

⁴ For everyone who has been born of God overcomes the world. And this is the victory that has overcome the world—our faith. ⁵ Who is it that overcomes the world except the one who believes that Jesus is the Son of God?

1 CORINTHIANS 15:56-57 (ESV)

⁵⁶ The sting of death is sin, and the power of sin is the law. ⁵⁷ But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ.

JOHN 16:33 (ESV)

³³ I have said these things to you, that in me you may have peace. In the world you will have tribulation. But take heart; I have overcome the world."

1 JOHN 4:4 (ESV)

⁴ Little children, you are from God and have overcome them, for he who is in you is greater than he who is in the world.